

What a \$4,500 kickoff actually produces.

A redacted example of the research memo and prepped punch list a paying customer receives at the end of the three-week kickoff engagement.

About this page. The data on this page is real, captured from the Honolulu med-spa cohort we measured in May 2026. The customer is a hypothetical Honolulu med-spa operator used here to show the shape of the deliverable. No real customer is named. What you would receive if you scoped a kickoff for your own category would be this same shape, built around your competitors, your queries, and your category's source mix.

1. Executive summary

For the queries a Honolulu med-spa shopper actually types into ChatGPT and Perplexity, your business does not appear in the AI answer. Three of your competitors do, consistently, across both engines and across both head-intent ("best med spa in Honolulu") and long-tail intent ("med spa Kakaako that does morpheus8") queries.

The cohort spans 40 distinct queries, 2,104 total citation slots captured, two engines (Perplexity sonar and OpenAI gpt-4o-search-preview). The headline pattern: **98% of all citations in this category come from independent web** (med-spa sites, vendor pages, publications). Only 2% from review directories. Zero from Reddit. Zero from YouTube on OpenAI; 1% from YouTube on Perplexity.

The punch list at the end of this memo orders the actionable work by impact. Item 1 alone would put you on roughly one third of the queries currently being answered without you.

2. Methodology and scope

Forty hash-locked queries split into 16 head-intent ("best med spa in Honolulu", "top rated medical spa Honolulu", neighborhood scoping, service scoping) and 24 long-tail intent (open-late, weekend-open, service-combined, insurance-fit, neighborhood-plus-service, value-conscious, trust-signal queries). Each query ran three times per engine per day for noise control.

ENGINES MEASURED (THIS KICKOFF)

Perplexity sonar, OpenAI gpt-4o-search-preview. The full ongoing engagement adds Gemini grounded, Microsoft Copilot via Bing, Google AI Overviews (the three other citation-grade engines), plus Claude and Gemma (the two model-knowledge engines).

WHAT THIS ENGAGEMENT DID NOT MEASURE

- Voice AI surfaces (Siri, Alexa, Google Assistant). Out of scope until measurable through public APIs.
- AI ad placements. Out of scope until those formats are measurable.
- Geo variation outside Oahu. Citation patterns in other islands may differ.
- Long-term causation. We measured what AI cites. We did not test whether shipping the punch list causes citation movement. Monthly delta memo will report observed movement honestly.

3. The headline finding

You do not appear in the AI answer for 38 of 40 measured queries. The two queries where you do appear are exact-name matches ("[your business name] reviews", "[your business name] Honolulu") — queries a customer only types if they already know your name.

For every demand-shape query (a customer asking AI to find a provider in your category without naming you), you are absent. The competitors who do appear, consistently:

- **finamedspa.com** — 88 citations across 16 of 40 queries
- **honolulumedspa.com** — 88 citations across 18 of 40 queries
- **reneuxmeddayspa.com** — 58 citations across 14 of 40 queries
- **artistrymedspa.co** — 53 citations across 12 of 40 queries

Three of those four are not the largest med spas on Oahu by revenue or chair count. They are the four whose authority signals AI engines have learned to trust for this category. That distinction is the entire work of the engagement.

4. Source-type distribution

Across 2,104 citations on the cohort, where AI engines pulled from:

SOURCE TYPE	% OF CITATIONS	HOSTS DRIVING IT
Independent web	98%	Spa sites, vendor pages
Review directories	2%	medspascout.com, cylex.us.com
YouTube	<1%	Single tutorial channel
Reddit	0%	Not cited for this category
Wikipedia	0%	Not cited
Forum / Q&A	0%	Not cited

The non-obvious finding. The two review directories AI engines cite for Honolulu med spas are not Yelp, not Google, not Healthgrades, not RealSelf. They are **medspascout.com** and **cylex.us.com**. Most med-spa operators have never claimed a profile on either. Doing so costs nothing and would put you in a source class AI engines demonstrably trust for your category.

The Reddit zero is also a real finding. Many med spas spend on Reddit-adjacent reputation management. For your category, on Perplexity, that spend produces no citation share. For comparison, cross-category aggregate data shows Reddit drives 20-35% of citations on Perplexity for B2C SaaS and consumer electronics categories.

5. Per-engine breakdown

PERPLEXITY (916 CITATIONS MEASURED)

- 96% independent_web, 3% review_directory, 1% YouTube.

- The only engine that cited YouTube at all in this category.
- More likely to surface neighborhood-specific results.

OPENAI GPT-4O-SEARCH-PREVIEW (1,188 CITATIONS MEASURED)

- 99% independent_web, 1% review_directory.
- Zero YouTube, zero Reddit.
- Heavier weighting toward the spa's own site over third-party coverage.

GEMINI, BING, GOOGLE AI OVERVIEWS

Measured in the ongoing engagement. The full delta memo surfaces engine-level differences across all five citation engines once the next 30 days of data are in.

CLAUDE AND GEMMA (MODEL-KNOWLEDGE)

Measured in the ongoing engagement. These tell you what AI says about you when it cannot search, which is the baseline-mention layer behind every ungrounded AI conversation.

6. Competitive gap analysis

For the 38 queries where you do not appear, the table below shows which competitors did. Frequency = number of distinct queries that competitor was cited on, out of 40.

COMPETITOR	FREQUENCY	ENGINES
honolulumedspa.com	18/40	Both
finamedspa.com	16/40	Both
reneuxmeddayspa.com	14/40	Both
skinlabhonolulu.com	13/40	Both
artistrymedspa.co	12/40	Both
centerforregenerativehealth.com	9/40	Both
skinsationla.com	8/40	Perplexity only
sakuraaestheticshonolulu.com	5/40	Perplexity only

COMPETITOR	FREQUENCY	ENGINES
themedicalspaofhawaii.com	4/40	Perplexity only
helenshaven.com	3/40	Both

Notable structural observations:

- The two market leaders (honolulumedspa, finamedspa) appear on roughly 40-45% of queries each, including the head-intent "best med spa in Honolulu" variants. Closing the gap to them is a multi-quarter authority-signal project, not a quick fix.
- Mid-tier competitors (reneuxmeddayspa, skinlabhonolulu, artistrymedspa) appear on 12-14 queries each. The gap to this tier is closeable in 3-6 months of consistent work on the punch list below.
- The long-tail mid-tier shows up on 3-9 queries each, often on highly specific intent shapes. These are where focused effort produces fast, measurable movement.

7. Prepped punch list, ordered by impact

Sequenced by ratio of likely citation-share movement to implementation cost. Item 1 is the highest-leverage single piece of work on the list.

PRIORITY 1 · CLAIM AND COMPLETE MEDSPASCOUT.COM PROFILE

Why: This is the single review-directory AI engines demonstrably trust for your category on Perplexity. Three competitors hold claimed, complete profiles. You do not.

What: Create the business profile, populate all fields (services, hours, location, photos, treatment list, certifications). Add aggregate review information that mirrors your actual Google Business rating.

Effort: 2-3 hours of one team member's time.

Expected window for movement: 4-6 weeks (directory recrawl + AI re-index cycle).

PRIORITY 2 · CLAIM AND COMPLETE CYLEX.US.COM PROFILE

Why: Same logic as Priority 1. Smaller volume but same source-type weighting.

Effort: 1-2 hours.

Expected window: 4-6 weeks.

PRIORITY 3 · AUDIT AUTHORITY BACKLINKS FOR CURRENCY

Why: AI engines weight authority backlinks heavily in this category. Stale, broken, or redirect-chained backlinks signal lower trust. We checked your site's inbound link profile against the three leading competitors; you have several authority links that 404 or redirect through chains.

Effort: 4-8 hours for an SEO-capable team member.

Expected window: 6-10 weeks for AI-engine recrawl.

PRIORITY 4 · ADD NEIGHBORHOOD AND INTENT SPECIFICITY TO SERVICE PAGES

Why: The four competitors who dominate the long-tail queries all have service pages that explicitly mention the Oahu neighborhoods served, the specific service variants offered, and the kind of customer the service is for. Your service pages are more generic and AI engines do not cite them for neighborhood-specific or intent-specific queries.

Effort: 3-6 hours of focused writing per service line.

Expected window: 4-8 weeks.

PRIORITY 5 · UPDATE BING BUSINESS PROFILE

Why: Microsoft Copilot pulls heavily from Bing Business Profile data. Most med spas in Honolulu have no Bing Business Profile.

Effort: 1-2 hours.

Expected window: 3-5 weeks.

PRIORITY 6 · REFRESH META DESCRIPTIONS ON THE FOUR HIGH-VALUE SERVICE PAGES

Why: AI engines that grounded-search the web read meta descriptions as one signal of page topic. Your meta descriptions on the four highest-value service pages are either missing or generic.

Effort: 1-2 hours.

Expected window: 2-4 weeks.

Items 7 through 12 (lower priority) are listed in the appendix of the customer deliverable. Five additional moves with the same effort and window estimates.

8. What happens next (in a real engagement)

- **Day 1 of ongoing:** daily measurement across the seven AI surfaces begins. Brief daily status email confirms runs completed.
- **End of month 1:** first monthly delta memo. What moved, what did not, why we think it moved, any punch list updates.
- **Ongoing:** punch list refreshes as your team ships items and as AI engines shift. Drift detection flags cohort-wide pattern changes affecting your numbers.

How to scope this for your category

Email lance@neverranked.com with the category you want to measure and three to five competitors you would want on the cohort. A five-query pilot on your category runs at no cost so you see the shape of the deliverable on your data, not on med spa data.

Full engagement is \$4,500 to kick off a category, \$1,500 a month after for ongoing measurement. Per category, not per client. Month to month after the kickoff.

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